

Mangaka Days

A real-time manga career and studio-management sim that begins in **Greater Tokyo on 1 April 1996**. Draw your first doujin in your parents' spare room, sell it, pitch it, survive the reader survey, hire your first assistant and build a studio that outlives the decade.



Title screen, in-game capture at 2560 x 1080

GENRE

Career and studio management sim

SETTING

Greater Tokyo, from spring 1996

ENGINE

Godot 4.7 with C#

PLATFORM

Windows on Steam, Steam Deck targeted

LAUNCH

Early Access, US\$9.99, English

STATUS

Private alpha 12, Tier 1 complete

Contents

Fourteen chapters, from the pitch to the road to Steam Early Access. Each chapter opens on a new page.

01	構想	Vision Software Inc., but for manga.	03
02	相棒	Companion Helper-Chan never leaves your side.	04
03	道のり	Journey From the kitchen table to the reader survey.	06
04	目標	Goals Five chapters, one page at a time.	08
05	制作	Production Five stages. One deadline. Never quite enough hours.	09
06	出版	Publishing Self-publish first. Then pitch for the magazines.	11
07	資金	Money Your savings are not the studio's money.	13
08	仕事場	Studio From the spare room to a floor in Minato.	14
09	時代	Era Thirty years of manga history, then a future you write.	16
10	画面	Interface A desk that fits every screen.	17
11	音	Sound Lo-fi study beats, playing now.	19
12	難易度	Difficulty Choose how hard the industry pushes back.	20
13	技術	Technology A deterministic simulation under a charming skin.	21
14	発売	Roadmap Finish the core, then open the doors.	22

EDITION 4 October 2026	BUILD 0.8.0 private alpha 12 and later work	STATUS Tier 1 complete
---------------------------	--	---------------------------

Software Inc., but for manga.

Mangaka Days sits between **Football Manager** and **Kairosoft**: decisions with real numbers behind them, presented through a tiny chibi world you want to keep watching. You direct the career of a prodigy mangaka, **Aki** by default, from a one-shot drawn at home to a serialized hit, a studio of assistants and an anime deal. The career follows the creator, not the company: change employers, found a studio or start again from home. Cancellation is a setback, never a game over, and the game never ends.

決断	愛嬌	東京	明快
Decisions with weight What to draw, where to pitch, when to hire. Every choice shows its cost, its odds and what happens next.	Charm you can watch An isometric 3D home and studio with chibi staff, family routines and light that follows the day.	Grounded in real Tokyo 1996 geography, rents, train fares and industry practice from Japanese sources, balanced to stay approachable.	Always know what is next Clear progress, actionable notifications, and a companion who guides without ever playing for you.

WHO IT IS FOR

Management and cosy-sim players who enjoy watching a small operation grow into a big one.

Manga readers curious about how chapters, surveys and cancellations really work.

Steam and Steam Deck players with 20 minutes or an evening to spare.



THE PROMISE IN ONE LINE

Your first sale in 20 minutes. Your first studio in a few evenings. Your legacy over decades.

THE NAME

Mangaka Days replaced the working title Mangaka Studio on 28 September 2026. The tagline on the title screen reads "A career told one page at a time." The logo, with Helper-Chan winking from its corner, sets the colours of the whole interface.

Logo and title art are AI-generated with NovelAI V5. Its terms allow store and title-screen use with Steam's AI disclosure. A commissioned designer brief covers the final logo, key art and Steam capsules.

Helper-Chan never leaves your side.

A loyal assistant with enormous blonde drill twintails, glasses, a red lanyard and a clipboard she never puts down. She is the creator's number one fan. She teaches, notifies and occasionally steps into the story, and she follows every career move for free.

Her twintails are her silhouette, so on the 3D model they stay deliberately wider than anyone else's. In store art she always appears in her adult, fully clothed reference design.



Approved portrait set. Routine tips use a compact card; important moments use the large panel.

No wage

Never on payroll or headcount

No bonus

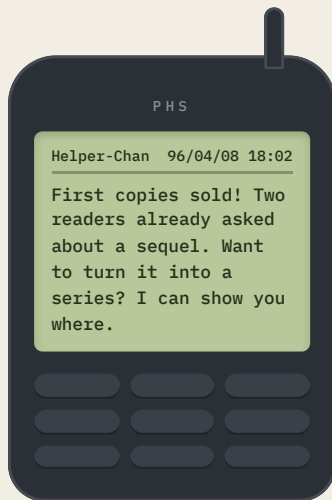
Adds nothing to production

Own desk

Across the studio island from yours

Always stays

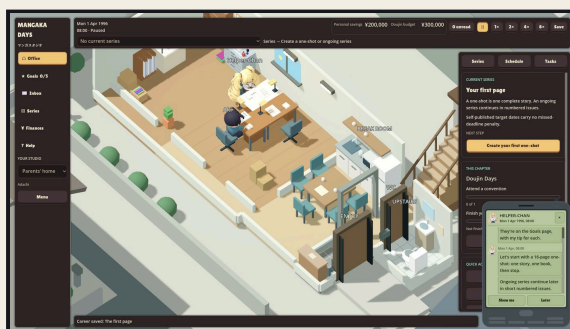
Choices shape memories, not loyalty



Guidance arrives as texts on her phone

Until the end of 2009 the thread sits on a green-screen PHS handset with a stub antenna. From 2010 it becomes smartphone chat bubbles, and the history carries over. Texts stay under 140 characters. The "Show me" reply highlights the right control but never spends money or moves time. Hide guidance and the phone folds to an icon with an unread count. Selling is taught as it happens: the first copy sold arrives as a text, a gold "First copy sold!" bubble and a pulsing Sold count in the header.

Mock-up with example text. Period note: DDI Pocket launched PHS text mail on 20 November 1996, so texts in April 1996 are an accepted anachronism.

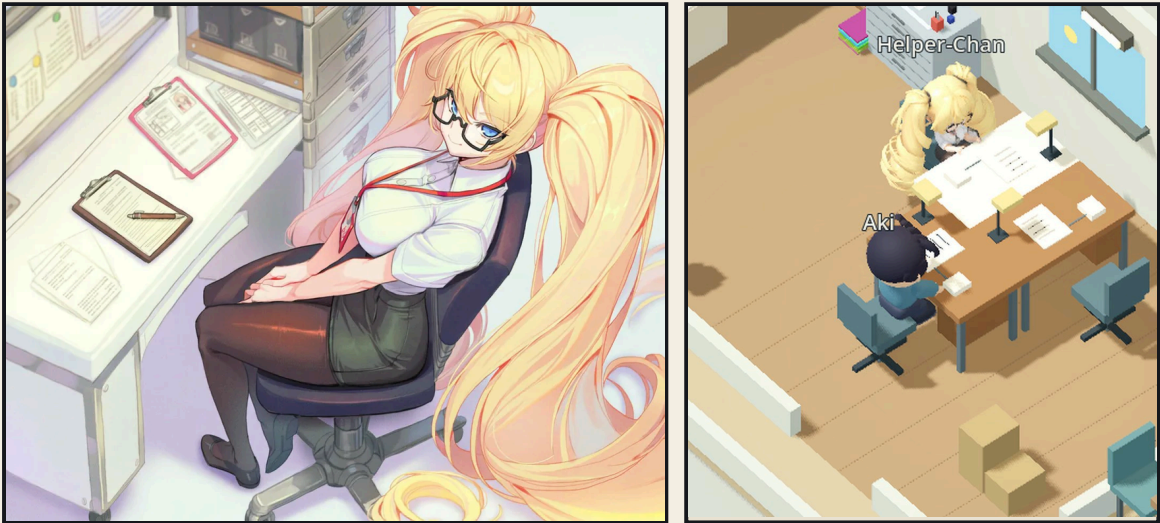


Left: day one at the desk island, captured just before the quick start cut her first texts to one. Right: the first sale, with the next step as reply buttons.

OPTIONAL STORY ARC: "THE FIRST READER"

SCENE 1 A place beside yours Her desk arrives in the workroom.	SCENE 2 The first page worth keeping She files the first finished page.	SCENE 3 Your first reader She reads the work before anyone else.
SCENE 4 Same clipboard, different day After a move or a setback.	SCENE 5 An archive of ordinary days The clipboard has become a history.	SCENE 6 The first reader, still Years later, she is still first in line.

Each scene offers two choices and can be skipped, deferred or replayed from the journal. At most one optional scene a day, at least a week between arc scenes, and everyday moments such as "Tea beside the draft" on a two-week cooldown.



"A moment at her desk" story illustration, and her rigged chibi model at the desk island with Aki.

From the kitchen table to the reader survey.

One continuous path, taught step by step, runs from a blank career through a first hire and a first setback. Contests and employment sit beside it as side routes. Dates come from a guided playtest career on the Standard preset; real times are tester A's first career on alpha.12.



09

Meet real deadlines

Chapters now close with the magazine at 18:00. The reader survey ranks you every issue, and weak runs bring a warning, then a risk of cancellation.

Debut
Four issues after the offer

10

Recover from a setback

A rejection, a warning or a cancellation. Helper-Chan names the rank, the safe line, the issues left and the weakest part, and the career carries on.

Year 2
Tester A: 3 h 22 min

Beyond the first hire: contests and awards, anime and merchandise licensing, incorporation, bigger premises, branches, rival studios poaching your staff, and the long climb toward an iconic series.

TIME AND PACING

One simulation tick is one in-game hour, played in real time. The working day runs 08:00 to 18:00, then a lights-out sequence carries the night to dawn.

1x 36 s per hour	2x Hyperlapse trails begin	4x Busy stretches	8x 45 s per working day	32x 11 s per routine day, after the first sale	Stops Offers, warnings, paydays, new texts
----------------------------	--------------------------------------	-----------------------------	-----------------------------------	--	--

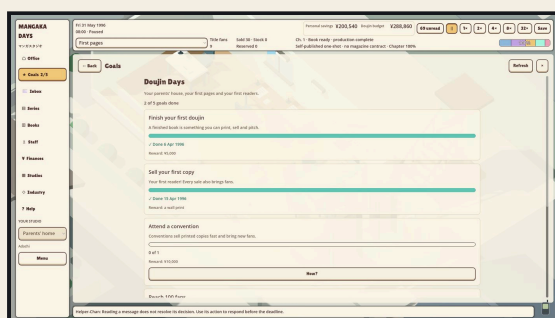
32x runs quiet days without the recap and drops back to your last speed when something needs you. Tester A spent 39% of a 5.5 hour session at 32x and averaged about 2.6 real hours per in-game year, a third of it paused. On days with no work, the night is skipped too.

Five chapters, one page at a time.

An open-ended career still needs a next step you can see. A goals board splits the career into five chapters with 27 goals, progress bars and a **How?** tip on each. Rewards are one-off: cash, fans, decorations that cannot be bought, unlocks and Helper-Chan scenes.

CHAPTER 1	CHAPTER 2	CHAPTER 3	CHAPTER 4	CHAPTER 5
Doujin Days	Rookie	Serialized	Studio Head	Legend
First doujin, first copy sold, a convention, 100 fans, ¥50,000 earned.	Pitch or enter a contest, an editor's verdict, a serialization or placing, 1,000 fans.	Ten chapters, the top ten, a first volume, a first hire, 10,000 readers.	Move out, three staff, incorporate, two series, an award shortlist.	An anime, merchandise, a million readers, an iconic series, a sustainable year.
Trophy shelf, free table	Pro desk, +10% on the next pitch	¥100,000, award plaque	¥300,000, display cabinet	A closing scene

Three Mastery goals sit beside the chapters. A finished goal keeps 32x running; a finished chapter stops for a celebration with the good-news music.



The Goals page, light theme. The rail badge reads "Goals 2/5".

SCREENS OPEN WHEN THEY ARE NEEDED

A new career shows only Office, Goals, Inbox, Series, Finances and Help, with speeds up to 8x. Each other part opens at its own moment with a "New" tag and one line from Helper-Chan, and never closes again.

OPENS	WHEN
Books	First doujin finished
Publishing and 32x	First sale
Industry	A serialization or contest result
Contests	The Rookie chapter
Staff and Studios	First hire

Experienced players can tick "show every screen" on the New Career page or in Settings. Rival job offers to Aki wait until Industry opens.

Five stages. One deadline. Never quite enough hours.

Every chapter moves through the same five stages a real manga studio uses. An auto-planner assigns the work, and you can pin, reorder or skip stages, set overtime, change cadence and adjust page counts.

ネーム Name	下描き Pencils	ペン入れ Inks	背景 Backgrounds	トーン Tones
1.2 h per page	1.5 h per page	1.0 h per page	1.0 h per page	0.5 h per page

Box width shows base hours per page. The red rule shows each stage's share of chapter quality: Name 35%, Pencils 30%, Inks 15%, Backgrounds and Tones 10% each.

98.8 h of base work in a 19-page weekly chapter	~52 h for Aki alone, working 1.9 times faster at skill 95	60 h in a six-day, ten-hour week. It fits, but only just, and the editor's review leaves no room for a buffer. An assistant on Backgrounds and Tones frees about 15 hours a week.
---	---	---

THE EDITOR'S GATE

Serialized chapters stop after Name for editor review: 24, 36 or 48 hours depending on the magazine's tier. Pencils wait until it clears. A redo costs a little reputation, and the third submission is always approved, so review is pressure rather than a wall.

QUALITY AND SHORTCUTS

A clean solo chapter at skill 95 scores about 96. Skipping Tones saves time and drops it to 86. Overtime rushes the work and trims quality, never below 70% of what it would have been. Skills grow with practice and mentoring.

TWELVE GENRES, EACH WITH ITS OWN HISTORY

Genre demand follows keyframes from 1996 to 2020, with random booms and your own influence on top. Slice of life climbs from a niche to a staple by 2010; fantasy rises steadily; sci-fi cools. Every genre has original cover art for the showcase screens.



Left: Production and work schedules, light theme. Right: work you can see. Sparkles fly from a seated worker to the header bar, and a bubble marks each finished stage. Reduced motion turns both off.

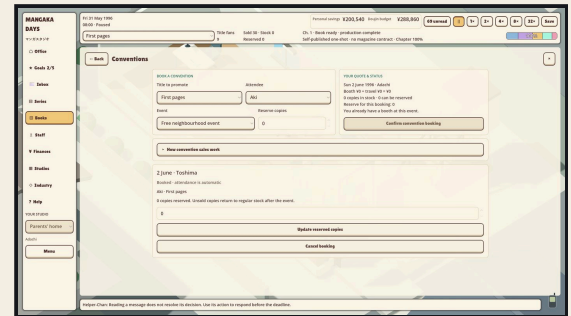
Self-publish first. Then pitch for the magazines.

Doujin work is yours: no deadlines, no penalties, your own prices. Magazine work pays page fees and royalties but brings the reader survey, the editor and the risk of cancellation.

DOUJIN: PRINT, LIST, SELL

PRINTER	RUN	DELIVERY
Copy shop	1 to 100	1 day
Local printer	50 to 1,000	4 days
Bulk printer	300 to 5,000	7 days

Online listings are free and the shop takes 30%. Copies sell through shop hours, 10:00 to 20:00 every day, so sales arrive as they happen, and internet reach grows year by year from almost nothing in 1996. Conventions come in three sizes: a free local event, a regional one in Toshima and the major summer and winter events at Ariake, with booths booked up to 28 days ahead.



Conventions: book a table, reserve copies, see the fare.

SIX MAGAZINES FROM THREE PUBLISHERS

MAGAZINE	AUDIENCE	TIER	CADENCE	PAGE FEE (1996)
Weekly Tokiwa Jump	Shonen	Tier 1	Weekly	¥9,000 to ¥20,000
Weekly Kaidan Magazine	Shonen	Tier 1	Weekly	¥9,000 to ¥18,000
Weekly Hoshigaku Sunday	Shonen	Tier 2	Weekly	¥8,000 to ¥15,000
Tokiwa Square	Shonen	Tier 2	Biweekly	¥8,000 to ¥14,000
Monthly Kaidan Afternoon	Seinen	Tier 3	Monthly	¥7,000 to ¥12,000
Monthly Hoshigaku Flowers	Shojo	Tier 3	Monthly	¥6,000 to ¥11,000

PITCHING

chance = base × quality × reputation × genre fit × trend

Base odds are 12%, 24% and 40% for tiers 1, 2 and 3, held between 2% and 95%. A contest win adds 10 points for a year, and finishing the Rookie chapter adds 10 points to the next pitch.

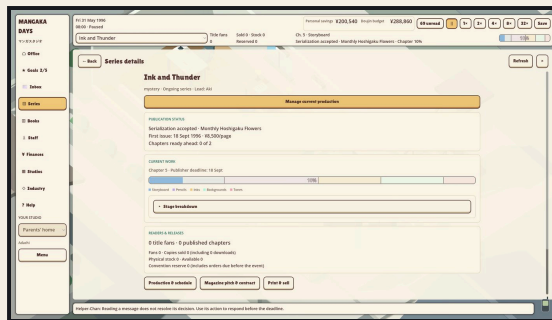
A rejection names the weakest factor and closes that magazine to you for 26 weeks, and the Pitch button says so until then. An offer debuts at the fourth issue close, which is why the buffer matters.

THE READER SURVEY

rank score = 60% readership + 40% craft

Adjusted by genre fit, trend and crowding from same-genre series.

New series are protected for six chapters. After that, weeks below the line bring a warning, then a cancellation roll. Long-running, popular and culturally important series earn more protection, and a truly iconic one can never be cancelled.



"Ink and Thunder" accepted at Monthly Hoshigaku Flowers: first issue 18 September 1996, ¥8,500 a page, chapters ready 0 of 2.

COLLECTED VOLUMES

Chapters gather into tankobon volumes six weeks after completion. Royalties follow the print run, as they do in Japan: the first 10,000 copies are paid on release, then each reprint milestone pays again. Digital and overseas editions open up as the timeline reaches them.

ENDINGS

Cancellation closes that magazine for a year and dents your track record, but a final volume still comes out and you can pitch again elsewhere. Ending a series properly after twelve or more chapters improves your standing.

Your savings are not the studio's money.

Personal savings and the doujin budget are always kept apart. Moving money between them is a deliberate act, and incorporation turns the budget into a proper company account. Figures below are the Standard preset.

PERSONAL	BUSINESS	COMPANY
¥200,000 Savings Your own money. Topped up by a part-time job (afternoon or evening shifts from ¥700 an hour), contest prizes and wages when employed. It can rescue a missed payday.	¥300,000 Doujin budget Pays for printing, conventions and internet, and receives sales, page fees and royalties. Later it carries salaries, rent and bills.	¥3.2M Incorporation ¥200,000 setup plus ¥3,000,000 capital, until the capital minimum is abolished in May 2006. Unlocks business credit at 8%.



First-hire safety. An assistant costs about ¥144,000 to ¥175,000 a month. Before you hire, the game shows runway: business cash plus confirmed page fees for the next 90 days, divided by monthly costs. Under three months, the line turns amber and asks you to confirm. It warns, it never blocks.

WHAT THINGS COST

Parents' house	¥0 rent
Four-desk studio in Nerima	¥60,000 / month
32-desk studio in Minato	¥800,000 / month
Internet	¥3,000 / month
Recruitment search	¥20,000
Company administration	¥20,000 / month

Prices follow real Japanese consumer prices from 1996, then rise 2% a year after 2026.

BALANCE TARGET, MEASURED

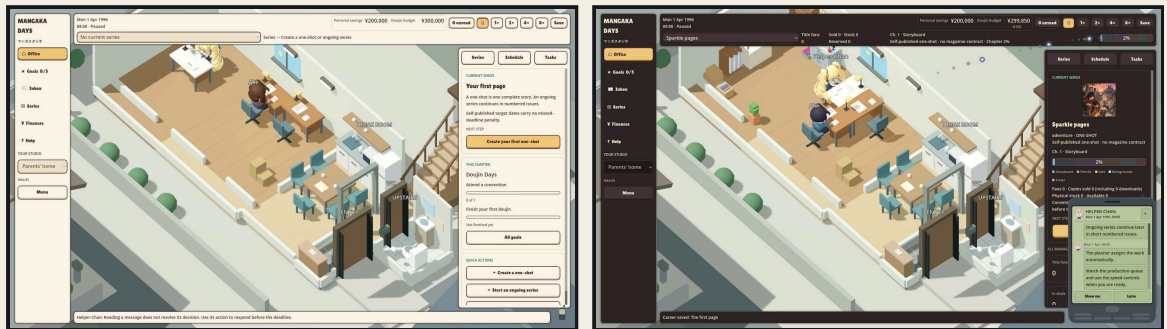
With sensible play the first three years stay solvent, a setback is recoverable, and money is neither trivially abundant nor a dead end.

EVIDENCE	RESULT
Six guided careers to April 1999, personal savings	¥0.55M to ¥10.3M
Careers that went bankrupt	None
Tester A after a cancellation	10 more months
Streaming sales vs weekly lump	-1.6% to +2.8%

The richest career rode a hit series. Balance across ten in-game years is Tier 2 work.

From the spare room to a floor in Minato.

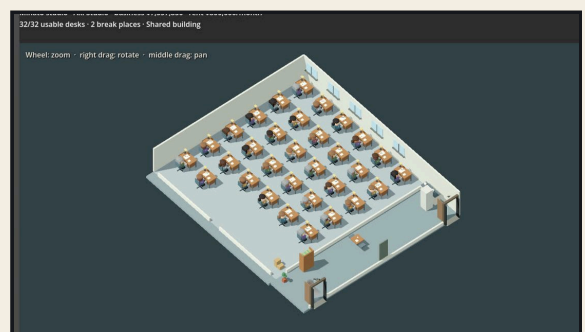
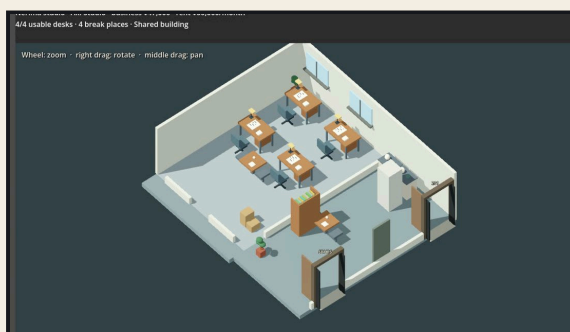
An orthographic, dollhouse-style 3D view with roofs lifted and front walls cut away. You can rotate, pan and zoom, and switch to furnishing mode to place desks on a 0.25 m grid. Everyone is a chibi about two and a half heads tall.



The parents' house: Aki's desk heads a desk island, Helper-Chan's desk faces the spare one, and the old alcove is now a studio corner with a bookcase, plan chest, cork board, light table and screentone rack. Kitchen, genkan, WC and rear stairs lead to the family's upstairs.

THE FAMILY

Mom and Dad live their own routines: they come down for meals, head out on errands and share breaks with you. They are pure atmosphere with no effect on the simulation, but they make the first months feel like home.



Left: a four-desk first studio in Nerima. Right: a 32-desk operation in Minato. Captured from the studio preview in an earlier build.

SIXTEEN RENTABLE PREMISES ACROSS FOUR TIERS

TIER	DESKS	WARDS AND MONTHLY RENT
Small	4	Nerima ¥60k, Itabashi ¥70k, Adachi ¥80k, Edogawa ¥90k
Growing	8	Suginami ¥120k, Nakano ¥140k, Katsushika ¥160k, Ota ¥190k
Established	16	Toshima ¥250k, Bunkyo ¥290k, Sumida ¥330k, Koto ¥380k
Large	32	Shinjuku ¥500k, Chiyoda ¥600k, Shibuya ¥700k, Minato ¥800k

HIRING

A pool of six candidates refreshes twice a month: juniors, generalists, specialists and, very rarely, a prodigy. Salary expectations rise with skill, and a paid search finds three more. A new hire needs a free desk with a reachable chair, and assistants take Backgrounds and Tones unless you change it.

WELLBEING

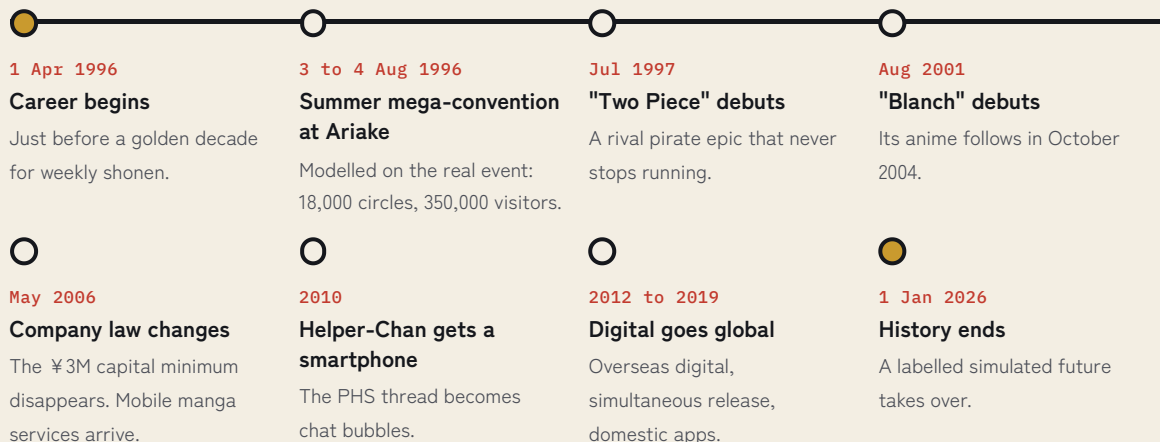
Staff get hungry, thirsty and tired, take breaks, and slow down when they are running on empty. Unhappiness or unpaid wages lead to warnings and notice. Rival studios may try to poach your best people.

GROWING

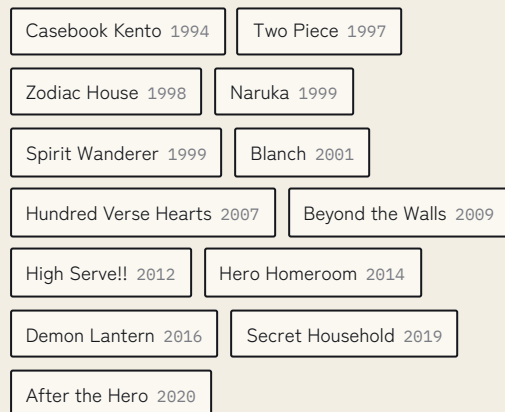
Move up through the desk tiers, open branches, take a job with another studio as an employed lead, or go home and start again. Old businesses go dormant, never deleted.

Thirty years of manga history, then a future you write.

Researched industry history runs from 1996 to the end of 2025, with fictional analogues of real series launching on their real dates. From 2026 the game says so plainly and switches to a clearly labelled simulated future.



THIRTEEN RIVAL ANALOGUES



They reach their real outcomes, but no rank is forced. A strong enough series can outrank any of them.

AWARDS AND ADAPTATIONS

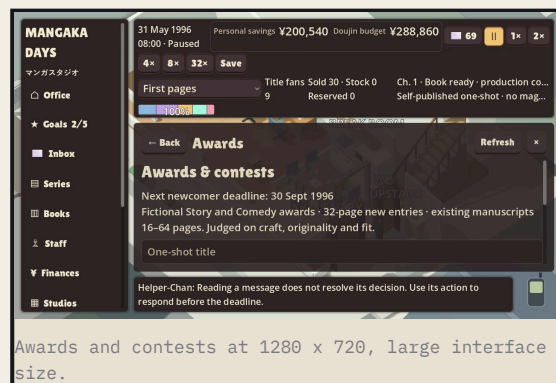
Twice-yearly one-shot contests with written feedback, an annual award for published work, and anime and merchandise partners who negotiate shares, schedule production and sometimes catch up to the manga.

TOKYO, RESEARCHED

All 23 wards plus Musashino, Mitaka, Kawasaki, Yokohama, Urawa and Chiba. Urawa, because Saitama City did not exist until 2001.

Train fares from distance: free within 3 km, then ¥170, ¥210 and ¥250 steps in 1996 prices.

Minimum wage by fiscal year, from ¥650 in 1995. Period office details such as steel desks and screentone sheets.



Awards and contests at 1280 x 720, large interface size.

A desk that fits every screen.

The office fills the whole canvas. A persistent left rail opens floating panels for Goals, the Inbox, Series, Books, Staff, Finances, Studios and Industry. A two-row header always shows the date, speed, both money pockets and the selected series' progress, stock and reservations. A right click steps back to the office.



21:9 ultrawide in the Evening studio theme: wider screens show more office, never stretched panels.



16:9 in the Manuscript paper theme.

BUILT IN FROM THE START

Two themes from the logo. Evening studio, or Manuscript paper. Every text colour reaches 4.5:1 contrast.

Interface size from 80% to 200%. Automatic follows Windows scaling, capped so a 1280 x 720 layout still fits.

Fullscreen or windowed, switched with F11 or Alt+Enter.

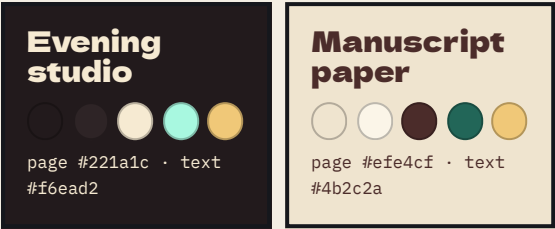
Status never relies on colour alone, icons are always labelled, nothing essential hides behind hover.

Disabled controls say why. Visible focus and keyboard order throughout.

Reduced motion turns off fades, sparkles and bubbles; trails run Full, Reduced or Off.

LOGO SLABS AND TWO PALETTES

Buttons are chunky slabs taken from the logo lettering: gold for the main action, mint for where you are, quiet slabs for everything else. Buttons and headings use Lilita One; body text and figures keep the reading font.



Lo-fi study beats, playing now.

Thirteen instrumental tracks of dusty late-1990s jazz-hop are in the game. Day and night pools follow the clock, studio tracks join once you move out, and a short quiet of 15 to 30 seconds sits between tracks. Under the music, the studio keeps its runtime-generated room tone and pencil strokes.

Mangaka Days Original Score

13 tracks, 2 to 3 minutes each

-16 LUFS, Ogg Vorbis

In the game since 28 September 2026

Title	dreamy, hopeful	2:25	Studio two	fuller band	3:13
Day, four tracks	2:00 to 3:12		Convention		2:42
Night one	3:07		Deadline	tense	2:00
Night two	3:08		Good news		2:44
Studio one	fuller band	1:59	Setback	melancholy	2:00

MOMENTS, GENTLY

A first sale, an offer, an award, a cancellation, a deadline at risk or a convention day crossfades to its own track over about three seconds, at most once a game day and never overnight or in menus. The clock is read only when a track starts, so 32x never makes the music jump.

VOLUME ON EVERY COMPUTER

Master, Music and Sound effects each have a slider, saved per computer rather than per career. Sound pauses when the window loses focus unless "Play sound even while unfocused" is ticked. Music uses its own random numbers, so it never changes a career.

Music is AI-generated with Suno on the Pro plan, which grants commercial use; provenance is recorded and will be disclosed on Steam. Tracks are swappable.

Choose how hard the industry pushes back.

Difficulty never touches the prodigy's talent. It changes the cushion you start with, how hard rivals and editors push, and how much grace a new series gets.

	RELAXED	STANDARD	CHALLENGING
Starting savings and budget	¥400k / ¥600k	¥200k / ¥300k	¥100k / ¥150k
Pitch odds	× 1.15	× 1	× 0.85
Rival survey strength	× 0.9	× 1	× 1.1
Editor waiting time	× 1.5	× 1	× 0.75
Protected opening chapters	9	6	4



Sandbox adds nine assists, from unlimited funds to instant production and no deadline penalties. Any Sandbox use permanently disables platform achievements for that save, and the ledger labels every subsidy.

A deterministic simulation under a charming skin.

The whole game world lives in an engine-free C# library. Godot owns real time and presentation; the simulation only ever sees whole-hour ticks and player commands, so the same seed and the same choices always produce the same career.

790 automated simulation tests passing	40 yrs of continuous play tested through save and load	v10 save format, importing every version since v3	~8 ms per frame with 32 staff at 8x on a desktop GPU
---	---	--	---

Saves you can trust. Named snapshots, three rotating daily autosaves, atomic writes and full career history.

Portable careers. A single export file carries the save and any imported cover art, and Continue opens the career you played last.

Guided playtest harness. A bot plays whole careers across seeds and presets to catch dead ends and runaway economies.

Local problem reports. One click packages logs, the save and a private session timeline, including any unexpected errors, for a tester to send; nothing uploads by itself.

Finish the core, then open the doors.

Nine sub-projects, twelve private alpha builds and three outside testers are behind us. The plan is tiered so that polish on the core journey comes before new content, and Tier 1 was signed off on 4 October 2026.

TIER 1 COMPLETE Complete core game A player who has never seen the game goes from a new career to a first sale, a magazine pitch, a serialization with real deadlines, a setback and a first hire, with no dead ends and no outside help.	TIER 2 Early Access ready ✓ Music, 13 tracks in the game - A playtest with strangers - Steam integration, about 25 achievements - Balance for 1996 to 2006 - Laptop and Steam Deck testing - Store page, commissioned art, trailer	TIER 3 During Early Access - More content and start dates - Deeper late-game systems - Localization, Japanese first - About 12 months, guided by players
--	--	---



Next: Tier 2. A playtest with strangers from the target audience, Steam integration and achievements, balance for 1996 to 2006, laptop and Steam Deck testing, then the store page, commissioned art and a trailer.

TIER 1 CHECKLIST

T1.1 ✓ The core journey works end to end	T1.2 ✓ Everything needed is taught in game
T1.3 ✓ Status is always clear	T1.4 ✓ The economy makes sense
T1.5 ✓ Pacing feels right	T1.6 ✓ Saves are reliable
T1.7 ✓ Stable over long sessions	T1.8 ✓ Extra systems cause no friction
T1.9 ✓ Every display and interface size is readable	T1.10 → A fresh player finishes without help, now a Tier 2 playtest

Ticked items carry evidence from testers A and B, the guided playtests and the automated checks. Teaching (T1.2) and pacing (T1.5) were signed off once the quick start trimmed the opening.

TIER 1 FIXES DELIVERED

Career guidance	First-hire safety	Setbacks	Difficulty	Debut wait	Mid-career pacing	Display sweep
Tester A and B fixes	Career goals	Screens that open	Streaming sales	Work feedback	Studio island	
Title screen	Logo restyle	Display settings	Quick start			

Mangaka Days

マンガカ・デイズ

Game Design Document, showcase edition, 4 October 2026, describing private alpha 12 plus the work since. Figures are subject to playtesting. Magazines, publishers and rival series are fictional analogues. All screenshots are in-game captures from development builds. The logo and title art are AI-generated with NovelAI V5, and the music with Suno.